

Hymn of Breaking Strain

*He went over it in his head, plate by plate, span by span, brick by brick, pier by pier,
remembering, comparing, estimating, and recalculating, lest there should be any mistake;
and through the long hours and through the flights of formulae that danced
and wheeled before him, a cold fear would come to pinch his heart...*

Text: Rudyard Kipling, 1935, alt.

Music: Leslie Fish, 1983

BREAKING STRAIN 76.76.76.76.6

arr. Kenan Schaefkofer, 2021

E♭m



D♭



C♭



1 The care - ful text-books mea - sure
2 But in our dai - ly deal - ing
3 The pru - dent text-books give it
4 We on - ly of Cre - a - tion
5 Oh, veil - ed, se - cret Pow - er,

(Let all who build be - ware!)
with stone and steel, we find
in ta - bles at the end:
(Oh, luck - ier bridge and rail)
whose paths we seek in vain,

E♭m



D♭



C♭



1 the load, the shock, the pres - sure
2 the gods have no such feel - ing
3 the stress that shears a riv - et,
4 a - bid the twin dam - na - tion:
5 be with us in our hour—

ma - ter - i - al can bear.
of guilt for hu - man - kind.
or makes a tie - bar bend,
To fail and know we fail.
of ov - er - throw and pain;

E♭m



C♭



D♭



E♭m



1 So when a buck - led gir - der
2 To no set gauge they make us,
3 what traf - fic wrecks mac - a - dam,
4 Yet we— by which sole to - ken
5 that we— by which sure to - ken

lets down a steel cas - cade,
for no laid course pre - pare,
what con - crete should en - dure.
we know we once were gods—
we know Thy ways are true—

E♭m



C♭



D♭



E♭m



1 the blame for loss, or mur - der
2 and pres - ent - ly o'er - take us
3 But we, of Eve and A - dam
4 take shame in be - ing bro - ken,
5 be - cause of be - ing bro - ken,

is on the ma - ker laid.
with loads we can - not bear:
have no such lit' - ra - ture,
how - ev - er great the odds.
may rise and build a - new.

Oh_____ the ma - ker, not the made!
too mer - ci - less to bear.
Oh_____ to warn us or make sure!
the bur - den of the Odds.
stand up and build a - new.